

media on March 29. "The LDF is seeking the mandate based on our track record, good governance practices and welfare measures for the needy." These include projects worth Rs 1.1 lakh crore, funded by the Kerala Infrastructure Investment Fund Board (KIIFB), which are complete or in the works. Among them are initiatives in transportation (coastal and hill highways), energy (Transgrid 2.0), education (hi-tech schools) and healthcare (Bio 360 Life Sciences Park). The first phase of the rehabilitation project for the Wayanad landslide victims was completed in March. The second phase of the Vizhinjam International Seaport expansion is also under way. Social security pensions have been hiked from Rs 1,600 to Rs 2,000 a month for 6.2 million eligible

ANI



SHOW OF HANDS
Congress's Rahul Gandhi with K.C. Venugopal (extreme left) and other leaders in Kozhikode, Mar. 31

A two-fold narrative anchors the LDF: to allow continuity for its vaunted 'Kerala model'; projecting the Modi regime's alleged anti-Kerala bias as its enemy

poor people, and the LDF claims to have built 500,000 houses as part of its project to 'eradicate homelessness' in the state.

Even with that breathless litany of pluses, there is no denying the anti-incumbency factor. Against the paternal image of Pinarayi shepherding Kerala through traumatic chapters—the 2018 flood, COVID, the Wayanad landslide—allegations of corruption and a high-handed 'iron hand' rule have kept up a matching pace. Autocratic centralisation of power is a persistent charge: several CPI(M) heavyweights, denied tickets, have decided enough is enough and have turned rebel. Foremost among them is G. Sudhakaran, a former state committee member and PWD minister in Pinarayi's first term, who has severed a 63-year association with the CPI(M) to fight as an Independent from his old fortress Ambalappuzha. His rebellion against 'Pinarayi exceptionalism' has found enthusiastic backing from the UDF. Even K.K. Shailaja 'Teacher', the former health minister who actually handled COVID, continues to face a perceived diminution: from all accounts, she has not suffered an unfavourable seat allocation too gladly.

Change is in the Air

While the LDF looks unsettled, the Congress-led UDF appears to be in the ascendant. The formation is determined not to spend another term in the Opposition. Its wins in 2024 and the local body polls last December have raised hopes. Preparations started early, with the enlisting of poll strategist Sunil Kanugolu, architect of the party's Telangana win. Three surveys were conducted to identify the best candidates for each constituency; seat allocation talks with allies Kerala Congress (Joseph) and the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) also proceeded apace.

The Congress is framing the 2026 election as a referendum on the LDF's corruption and fiscal mismanagement

THE CHALLENGER



V.D. Satheesan, 61, Congress
Leader of the Opposition

KEY STRATEGIES

- Exposing 'mega corruption' in the LDF government's development claims, alleging that its feeder institutions made huge profits
- Alleging that the CPI(M) and BJP have made a deal to deny the Congress victory in the state. Congress star campaigners, including Rahul Gandhi, allege the quid pro quo for the 'CJP deal' is the Centre going slow on the cases against Pinarayi
- The consolidation of all minority votes. Ensuring that the IUML's Muslim voters and KC(J)'s Christian sympathisers transfer their vote to the Congress across the state
- The new FCRA Bill, brought in March, has rattled Christian churches with its strictures on foreign contributions. It may help jolt them back to the UDF